Incident Report Template and Writing Guide

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Use this file as the skeleton for your own report. Each section below gives you a short brief on what belongs there and the questions your writing should answer, not finished sentences to copy. Replace every brief with your own findings, written in your own words, citing your own packet numbers.

If a sentence you write could be pasted into this file unchanged and still sound generic, it is too generic. Every section should contain something that only makes sense once you have actually looked at this specific capture.

Report header

Start with a short block identifying the report: a reference name or number you choose, the capture file analysed, the date, your name, and a one-word severity assessment you are prepared to justify later in the report.

1. Executive Summary

Brief: Three to five sentences, written last, after everything else is done. State what the attacker achieved, in the end, and how. Someone who reads only this section should walk away with the correct overall conclusion, including which phase of the attack actually succeeded and which did not.

Checklist

- Does it name the attacking host and the final outcome?
- Does it distinguish between what looked threatening and what actually worked?
- Could someone disagree with it after reading your evidence sections? If so, rewrite it.

2. Scope and Methodology

Brief: State what you analysed (the capture, its approximate time span and packet count) and how (Wireshark version, the specific filters and techniques you relied on, such as TCP stream reassembly). Note what you did not have access to and therefore could not verify from this evidence alone.

Checklist

- Named at least two specific filters or techniques you actually used.
- Stated at least one thing you could not confirm from network traffic alone.

3. Relevant Hosts and Network Observations

Brief: List every distinct IP address you identified and assign it a role (ordinary client, server, resolver, attacker). For the address you label as the attacker, justify that label with observed behaviour, not assumption.

Checklist

- A short table or list: address, role.
- A sentence explaining why the suspected attacker address is labelled that way, referencing at least one specific behaviour.

4. Reconnaissance Findings

Brief: Describe the sequence of requests you believe represents enumeration. State the source, the paths requested, the response codes, and the timing between requests. Explain, in your own words, why this pattern looks automated rather than like ordinary browsing, and what it reveals about the application’s structure.

Checklist

- A table of packet number, path, and response code.
- A stated request interval or pacing observation.
- One sentence connecting this phase to what happens next.

5. Brute-Force Analysis

Brief: Describe the authentication attempts you found: the target endpoint, how many attempts, the request method and body pattern, and the response to every single one. State plainly, with evidence, whether any attempt succeeded. Identify where this activity stops and for how long nothing follows it.

Checklist

- A packet-referenced count of attempts.
- A direct statement, backed by specific response evidence, on whether this phase succeeded.
- The length of the gap afterwards, and what else was happening on the network during it.

6. SQL Injection Evidence

Brief: Walk through the specific request or requests that differ in kind from the brute-force attempts. Quote or closely describe the unusual field values, the exact response each produced, and explain step by step how one leads to the next. Do not stop at the first unusual response; follow it to its conclusion.

Checklist

- At least two distinct requests identified and distinguished from each other (a precursor and a result, if both exist).
- A plain-English explanation of what made the payload unusual.
- A statement of what the server’s response headers or body actually granted, not just its status code.

7. Incident Timeline

Brief: A table, ordered by time, of every phase boundary and decisive event: when each phase starts and ends, and the packet number that marks each entry. This section should let a reader reconstruct the whole incident from the table alone.

Checklist

- Every phase from your earlier sections appears here with a packet number and timestamp.
- The gap between phases is shown explicitly, not just implied.

8. Root Cause and Impact Assessment

Brief: State the underlying weakness that allowed this incident, in your own technical words, not just “SQL injection” as a label. Then state what you can confirm actually happened as a result, based only on this capture, separating what is confirmed from what is merely possible.

Checklist

- A one or two sentence technical explanation of the root cause.
- A clear line between “confirmed by this evidence” and “plausible but unconfirmed.”

9. Defensive Recommendations

Brief: For each phase of the incident, propose at least one control that would have prevented or detected it, specific enough that someone could action it. Prioritise them: which single fix addresses the actual root cause, as opposed to controls that would only have caught the noisier, unsuccessful activity.

Checklist

- At least one recommendation tied specifically to the root cause.
- At least one recommendation tied to detection, not just prevention.
- Recommendations are ordered by priority, with a reason given for the ordering.

10. Limitations and Unresolved Questions

Brief: List what this capture cannot tell you. Think about attribution, anything after the capture ends, and anything that would require logs, source code, or systems you do not have access to.

Checklist

- At least three distinct limitations, not restatements of each other.
- None of them contradict a claim you made as “confirmed” earlier in the report.

11. Evidence References

Brief: Build a table with columns for timestamp, packet number, observation, interpretation, and confidence (high, medium, or low). An observation is something the capture directly shows; an interpretation is your conclusion from it. Keep these visibly separate, and be honest about confidence, not everything deserves “high.”

Checklist

- At least six rows covering every phase of the incident.
- At least one row marked medium or low confidence, with a reason.
- The exact Wireshark filters you relied on, listed once at the end.

Before you submit

Read your Executive Summary and your Evidence References table back to back. If the summary claims something the table does not support with a specific packet, go back and fix one of the two.